

UW ECONOMICS SOCIETY

[HOME](#) [ABOUT US](#) [EXECUTIVE TEAM](#) [ORIGINAL CONTENT](#) [FEATURES](#) [STAY CONNECTED](#)



 Hannah
Saul
Hannah Saul

ORIGINAL ARTICLES November 18, 2020 □ 1 Comment

The World's Scarcest Resource

Written By: Hannah Saul

Water consumption is not something that is commonly thought about by the average Canadian. For many, they're available with the turn of a tap nozzle, or a pour of the Brita in the fridge. It may even be included in your rent, and you're able to take that extra-long shower or leave the tap running on someone else's dime.

The truth is, someone else's dime does not always exist when it comes to water consumption.

Water Crisis'

With water covering 70% of the planet, it's difficult to recognize the urgency of water conservation (1). Yet, freshwater makes up only 3% of the world's water supply – and 66% of that freshwater is frozen away in glaciers or otherwise unusable (2).

Throughout the world, 1.1 billion people lack access to water, and an additional 2.7 billion find it scarce for at least one month of a year (3). At this current consumption rate, it is predicted that two-thirds of the world's population will face water shortages (4), and water scarcity will only be accelerated as rapidly growing urban areas put pressure on water resources. At this current consumption rate, it is predicted that two-thirds of the world's population will face water shortages (5), and water scarcity will only be accelerated as rapidly growing urban areas put pressure on water resources. While there is not a declared global water shortage, individual countries and regions have been hit disproportionately hit by the issue of water conservation.

While there is not a declared global water shortage, individual countries and regions have been hit disproportionately hit by the issue of water conservation. For those that do have access to water, the sanitation levels remains a problem, with 2.4 million people being exposed to water-borne diseases annually (6).

In a developed country like Canada, it's difficult for many to recognize water scarcity as something that affects them close to home. Yet, we are watching the Flint water crisis run rampant for the past 6 years.

We cannot merely turn our nose up at the Americans and how they have handled this ongoing health crisis, when we have our own less-reported water issues here at home. As of November 2020, there are 826 First Nations communities in Canada under a Boil Water Advisory (7).

Across the country, you can find three types of water advisories – do not use, do not consume, and boil water. Most commonly found is the boil water advisory, in which communities are instructed to boil water for at least one minute before use.

The history of water issues in First Nation communities

Access to clean water in these communities is not merely an issue of recent history, but one with deep historical roots tying all the way back into colonization. First Nation communities receive far less funding for clean water than their neighbouring municipalities (9) – they are regulated federally, not provincially.

In 1876, when the Indian Act was passed, the reserve system that we know today was established. In accordance with existing treaties, the act deciphered which tracts of land would be for First Nations people, with the purpose of allowing settlers to set up farms.

At this point in time, the government's goal was to ultimately force the assimilation of First Nations people – stripping them of not only their land, but their culture and autonomy.

As a result, not much thought was given into the infrastructure in these areas. Dawn Martin-Hill, one of the founders of the Indigenous Studies Program at McMaster University, notes that “they didn't put in roads, housing, or infrastructure because they thought we were going to die out...they never thought we would still be here. The fact that we are is a testimony to our resilience and our strength as people” (10).

What has been done

During his campaign in 2015, Justin Trudeau promised to eliminate all long-term boil advisories by March 2021. With just under 4 months left

to go, it is unlikely that this target will be met.

The Liberal government has promoted public-private partnerships (P3s) – though history has demonstrated the high cost of P3s, leading to the privatization of water, loss of community control, and jobs (11).

For years, Canadian governments have spent billions trying to ensure that First Nations are able to get clean water flowing from their taps. The reasoning behind the lack of potable water varies. In some cases, the community is extremely remote. In others, the insufficient infrastructure is to blame.

The government has a list of ideas and long-term drinking water advisories, with ideas such as temporary and permanent repairs, new systems, and better training and monitoring methods (12).

Only a 30 minute drive from Hamilton, Six Nations of the Grand River in southern Ontario is one of these communities hit by a water advisory. In 2014, the government gave the community money for a water treatment plant – but no money remained to be able to operate it (13).

Today, people still live there without clean drinking water, and almost nobody has proper piping into their houses to carry the new, clean water (14). Most continue to buy large jugs of fresh water.

What still needs to be done

Eradicating this issue will not be a quick fix – and definitely not one with a target end date of 3 months from now. A lot of time and resources will be necessary to not only update infrastructure in these areas, but ensure that proper and continuous monitoring of unforeseen issues is in place.

A proposal by the Council of Canadians states that raising corporate tax rates from 15 to 15.5 percent would be sufficient in getting the monetary

resources needed to ensure that all First Nations' have access to proper water systems (15).

No matter the course of action decided on, one thing is for certain – this issue has been going on for far too long. There is no reason that anybody should be scrounging for water, and the government must put their words into action.

Citations

1. Water Scarcity. (n.d.). Retrieved November 15, 2020, from <https://www.worldwildlife.org/threats/water-scarcity>
2. Ibid.
3. Ibid.
4. Ibid,
5. Ibid,
6. Ibid.
7. Water advisories in Canada (n.d.). Retrieved November 15, 2020, from <https://www.watertoday.ca/map-graphic.asp>
8. Ibid.
9. Kristahessey, T. (2019, October 03). Why some First Nations still don't have clean drinking water – despite Trudeau's promise. Retrieved November 15, 2020, from <https://globalnews.ca/news/5887716/first-nations-boil-water-advisories/>
10. Ibid.
11. Safe Water for First Nations. (n.d.). Retrieved November 15, 2020, from <https://canadians.org/fn-water>
12. Government of Canada; Indigenous and Northern Affairs Canada. (2020, February 17). Ending long-term drinking water advisories. Retrieved November 15, 2020, from <https://www.sac-isc.gc.ca/eng/1506514143353/1533317130660>
13. Kristahessey, T. (2019, October 03). Why some First Nations still don't have clean drinking water – despite Trudeau's promise. Retrieved November 15, 2020, from <https://globalnews.ca/news/5887716/first-nations-boil-water-advisories/>

14. Ibid.

15. Safe Water for First Nations. (n.d.). Retrieved November 15, 2020, from <https://canadians.org/fn-water>

- **Banner**



Previous Post

Economics Newsletter – Week of November 2nd 2020

Next Post

Economics Newsletter – Week of
November 16th 2020

1 Comment on "The World's Scarcest Resource"

ECONOMICS NEWSLETTER – WEEK OF NOVEMBER 16TH 2020 | UW ECONOMICS SOCIETY
NOVEMBER 21, 2020 AT 9:35 AM

REPLY ☐

[...] The World's Scarcest Resource by Hannah Saul [...]

Leave a Reply

Your email address will not be published. Required fields are marked *

COMMENT

NAME *

EMAIL *

WEBSITE

POST COMMENT

☐

NOTIFY ME OF FOLLOW-UP COMMENTS BY EMAIL.

☐

NOTIFY ME OF NEW POSTS BY EMAIL.

Copyright 2025 UW Economics Society